

Ethics of a monitoring system at the workplace

Ralitsa Simova, Viktoria Ivanova – 7MI3400799, Nikolay Georgiev

A monitoring system at the workplace may seem like a good idea to the company management at first. The company wants to ensure that staff are working responsibly and one way to ensure that is to have the workers know that their actions and tasks are being tracked at all times. HR may also consider this a good idea as it can help resolve work conflicts more efficiently and they may identify problematic staff behaviour earlier. But will this system actually help the working process or will it do more harm to the company image and staff morale. Moreover, is it ethical to track staff behaviour at all times.

When looking at this problem, first we need to identify who it involves. At first glance, the new system will affect everyone at the company. However, for people of different positions it will have a different effect. We can identify four major groups of the working people in the company with their unique perception of the system - regular staff, management, HR and the owners/board of directors. We can look at them separately and consider how this system may help them at work or how it might harm them.

1. Effects on the staff

The introduction of such a system could raise mixed feelings in the staff. From one side, everything becomes more structured and transparent, on the other hand, ethical concerns must be carefully considered.

Firstly, one possible advantage for workers is that monitoring data, when analysed responsibly, could expose structural inefficiencies such as unbalanced workloads or poorly designed workflows. Addressing these issues may lead to fairer task allocation and improved working conditions given that the monitored data is interpreted within its proper context. Moreover, if monitoring systems are designed with transparency and auditability in mind, the collected data may serve as objective evidence in resolving workplace disputes, thus offering a degree of protection to employees, who are honest and follow the code of conduct.

Nevertheless, the disadvantages for workers are considerable. Live-time monitoring could be and most likely be perceived as intrusive or “creepy”. Not only that, but there is also increased risk that individual-level data could be re-identified or misinterpreted, leading to unfair evaluations or disciplinary decisions. Being constantly surveilled could contribute to increased stress, reduced trust and a deterioration of workplace morale making people not as communicative as they were before.

2. Effects on Human Resources

This monitoring system will grant HR with detailed information about each employee work process. This will ensure that they are able to make faster decisions based on collected data. They will be able to resolve conflicts more efficiently as worker behaviour will be tracked and stored. However, there will be some drawbacks.

Firstly, this system should comply with data protection laws. It should be clear to the employees how this data is tracked and stored and what it will be used for. HR should organise trainings on these topics and they should be ready to answer any potential questions or complaints. Moreover, processing and analysing this data will increase the workload on HR. If they want to be able to use the data to make more educated decisions, they will need to be able to go through it first.

This data, however, is not reliable - it may be incomplete or misleading. HR should abstain from relying on it too heavily to make decisions about employees as the conclusion they may draw from it may be inaccurate. They should also be careful not to create biases accidentally - for example favouring a person who always looks busy.

Lastly, this system may undermine the HR image and the trust in the department. HR should protect employees' rights, not take them away. HR should not be able to track interpersonal relationships as doing so will create a culture of suspicion, discourage natural collaboration and may lead employees to feel that every interaction is being judged or monitored for hidden meaning.

3. Effects on Management and Board of directors

Introducing a real-time staff monitoring system may also sound like an outstanding invention for the management – from the ones which are working closely with the employees to the directors who are responsible for company decisions, setting strategy and protecting stakeholders' interests. Unfortunately, the truth might be radically different.

From a positive perspective, the advantages will be increased traceability, thus allowing for better management and identifying inefficiencies at some company units. Furthermore, clear performance review for each person can be made, without missing important details and moments of the overall working process. In addition to that, managers could use the data to allocate resources better to support staff who may be overloaded. This real-time tracking system can reduce the management workload for monitoring the staff performance all the time, which may lead to more time for focusing on business decisions and stakeholders' needs.

On the other hand, the disadvantages are overwhelming, with the ethical norms being violated. Employees may feel mistrusted or stressed, which could reduce morale and long-term productivity,

harming management goals. From the CEO perspective, the company whole reputation can be lost, since the excessive surveillance might break the company image and might become a non-preferred workplace. Long term, talented employees might stop choosing the company as a desired place to work, only because they will be monitored all the time, which would reduce productivity.

4. Possible middle ground solution

Solutions that satisfy all parties can be devised, selectively adopting the beneficial aspects of the system, without causing harm to employees.

By following the agile methodologies, a daily meeting can be established, in which each employee reports their progress, struggles and the circumstances of the previous working day, will give the management the security needed that their employees are fulfilling their responsibilities as well as having an insight into team dynamics and ongoing issues. In this manner, the lower-level management can communicate observations and concerns to the senior management without giving the feeling of constant monitoring among employees.

Furthermore, employees may feel more inclined to openly share their experiences if management consistently provides appropriate support and effective solutions to workplace challenges.

In conclusion, a workplace monitoring system may initially appear beneficial to management and HR by promising greater efficiency, accountability, and conflict resolution. However, its ethical implications must not be overlooked. A system that prioritizes control over autonomy risks creating a culture of surveillance rather than collaboration. Management should prioritise staff voluntarily sharing their work progress, rather than monitoring them. This way productivity would be improved, without sacrificing the company morale.

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